



IMPORTANT INSIGHTS + ACTION GUIDE

Who Moved My Cheese?

An A-Mazing Way to Deal with Change in Your Work and in Your Life

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Foreword by Kenneth Blanchard · First published 1998

ORIENTATION

The Question and the Answer

The book's central question

Something you depend on — a job, an income, a relationship, your health, a role you are proud of — is eventually going to change, run out, or be taken away, and you will probably not be warned. What do you do then?

The author's central answer

Johnson's answer is that the delay is the problem, not the change. Most of the damage people suffer does not come from the loss itself but from the stretch of time they spend refusing to accept that it happened. And the delay is not caused by weakness — it is caused by intelligence, by a mind capable enough to build an airtight case for standing still. So the work is done before and around the loss: inspect what you depend on while it still works, laugh at your own stuck pattern rather than arguing with it, name a specific destination vividly enough to pull you forward, and move earlier than feels necessary.

ORIENTATION

The Framework: Four Responses, Seven Reminders

The book carries two structures. The four characters are a diagnostic — not four kinds of people, but four responses available inside one person, situation by situation. The Handwriting on the Wall is the sequence Haw writes out at the end, and it is a loop rather than a checklist: its last item returns you to its first.

FOUR RESPONSES — AND THE QUESTION EACH ONE ASKS

Sniff — Smells change coming while things still look fine.	Where am I already sensing something and choosing not to look at it?
Scurry — Moves as soon as the situation changes, without a long analysis.	What would I do today if I stopped waiting for more information?
Hem — Denies and resists, fearing change will lead to something worse.	What am I calling unfair instead of calling over?
Haw — Hesitates, then adapts in time once he sees change can lead to something better.	What would make the new thing worth wanting rather than merely surviving?

SEVEN REMINDERS — THE HANDWRITING ON THE WALL

Change Happens	They keep moving the cheese.
Anticipate Change	Get ready for the cheese to move.
Monitor Change	Smell the cheese often, so you know when it is getting old.
Adapt To Change Quickly	The quicker you let go of old cheese, the sooner you can enjoy new cheese.
Change	Move with the cheese.
Enjoy Change	Savor the adventure and enjoy the taste of new cheese.
Be Ready To Change Quickly, Again And Again	They keep moving the cheese.

IMPORTANT INSIGHTS · PART 1 OF 4

Reading the Story Correctly

Three things the book states plainly and most readers skip.

Cheese is what you believe makes you happy — not what you deserve

WHAT IT SAYS

Blanchard defines cheese before the parable begins: a job, a relationship, money, a big house, freedom, health, recognition, spiritual peace, even an activity like jogging or golf. The definition is deliberately built on belief. We pursue cheese because we believe it will make us happy, we become attached when we get it, and losing it can be traumatic. The maze is wherever you spend your time looking — your organization, your community, your relationships.

WHY IT MATTERS

If you hear “cheese” as a job and “maze” as a company, the book shrinks into a workplace pamphlet. Its actual scope is anything you have come to count on and stopped examining, which for most people includes several things far more important than a job.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

In the story, the same word covers two completely different things: Haw’s cheese is feeling safe and having a loving family someday. Hem’s cheese is becoming a big cheese in charge of others. Both are called Cheese; only one of them is a position.

IN PRACTICE

Before you use anything else in this book, write down what your cheese actually is, in specific terms. Not “my career.” The particular arrangement you would grieve.

Remember — Cheese is a belief about happiness, not a claim about desert.

The four characters are four responses inside you, not four kinds of people

WHAT IT SAYS

The page titled Parts of All of Us states the reading rule outright: the four characters are intended to represent the simple and the complex parts of ourselves, regardless of age, gender, race, or nationality. They are not personality types and not a tool for sorting colleagues.

WHY IT MATTERS

Used as a sorting tool the framework becomes a way to name other people's failures, which is precisely the use that guarantees you get nothing from it. Used as intended it is situational: you can sniff out change early in your business and be a stubborn Hem about your health in the same week.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

In the discussion at the end, everyone answers Angela's question in the past tense and about one specific episode. Carlos was Hem, about one unexpected change of jobs. Nobody in the book claims to be a character.

IN PRACTICE

Never ask "who am I?" Ask "which of these am I being, right now, about this particular thing?" — and answer it once per situation, not once per lifetime.

Remember — The question is never who they are. It is which one you are being today.

The book does not claim that all change is good

WHAT IT SAYS

Two caveats sit in the source and almost never survive the retelling. The publisher's front note addresses the fear that the story suggests all change is good and that people should mindlessly conform to unnecessary changes imposed by others, and states plainly that this is not in the story. Blanchard writes that everyone knows not all change is good or even necessary.

WHY IT MATTERS

This book is frequently handed out during layoffs and reorganizations as an argument for compliance. The text does not support that use, and knowing so lets you take the useful part without swallowing the framing that comes with it.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

In the discussion, Frank says he thinks some things should not change — that he wants to hold on to his basic values — and no one in the group corrects him.

IN PRACTICE

Separate two questions that the parable's momentum tends to fuse: is this change good, and has this change already happened. The book is only about the second.

Remember — The argument is about what to do after a change is irreversible — not about welcoming every change on offer.

IMPORTANT INSIGHTS · PART 2 OF 4

How It Traps Capable People

The trap is not stupidity. Every step of it is defensible, which is why it holds.

Your most important dependency is your least inspected one

WHAT IT SAYS

Haw's principle is that the more important your cheese is to you, the more you want to hold on to it. Attachment scales with meaning — and inspection scales inversely. Hem and Haw move their homes closer to Cheese Station C, build a social life around it, decorate the walls, and bring friends by to admire the pile. Johnson names the result: their confidence grew into the arrogance of success, and soon they were so comfortable they did not even notice what was happening.

WHY IT MATTERS

By the time the cheese matters enough to structure your life around, checking on it feels both unnecessary and faintly disloyal. That is the exact moment the mice keep checking and the Littlepeople stop.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

The story notes that Hem and Haw had no idea where the cheese came from, or who put it there. They just assumed it would be there — while the mice inspected the station every single morning before eating.

IN PRACTICE

Rank your dependencies by how much they matter, then look at the top of the list first. Your intuition will route you toward the ones you feel least secure about; that intuition is backwards.

Remember — What you would grieve most is what you are checking least.

“I didn’t cause this” is the most reasonable sentence in the book

WHAT IT SAYS

Hem’s argument for staying is a tight loop: we are Littlepeople, we are special, this should not happen to us, we are entitled to our cheese — because we did not cause this problem. Somebody else did, and we should get something out of it. Every clause is defensible on its own.

WHY IT MATTERS

It is very often true that you did not cause the change. It is never true that this excuses you from responding to it. Hem has fused fault and responsibility into a single question, and because the first half is accurate the whole thing feels sound.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Haw’s reply is the whole book in one line: I know we are smarter — but we do not seem to be acting smarter at the moment.

IN PRACTICE

When you catch yourself building a case, check whether it is a case about who is at fault. If it is, it cannot also be a plan, and you are likely to mistake finishing it for progress.

Remember — Fault and responsibility are separate questions. Only one of them is yours to act on.

Working harder in an empty room is denial that looks like diligence

WHAT IT SAYS

Hem decides the cheese must be nearby — maybe hidden behind the wall. So they return with tools, knock a hole in the wall of Cheese Station C, find nothing, and then start earlier, stay longer, and work harder. After a while, all they have is a large hole in a wall. Haw begins to realize the difference between activity and productivity.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the most socially rewarded form of denial available to a competent person. It feels like effort, it reads to everyone around you as commitment, and it produces nothing. Nobody will interrupt you while you are doing it.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

The hammer and chisel are not useless tools. In the sequel excerpt, Hem carries the same hammer and chisel out into the maze with him. Nothing about his capability was wasted — it had been aimed at the wrong wall.

IN PRACTICE

Ask what the last month of effort actually produced, not how much of it there was. If the honest answer is a hole in a wall, the problem is aim, not intensity.

Remember — Effort is not evidence of adapting. Check the aim before you add hours.

Waiting is not free — you lose your edge while you deliberate

WHAT IT SAYS

Hem's final proposal is to sit and see what happens, on the theory that sooner or later they have to put the cheese back. They wait. They grow weak from hunger and stress. Their homes stop being nurturing places. They sleep badly, have nightmares about not finding cheese, have less energy, and become irritable. Haw sees it: the longer they stay, the worse off they will be. He knew they were losing their edge.

WHY IT MATTERS

The implicit assumption behind deliberating is that the option to move will still be there, in the same condition, whenever you decide. It will not. Haw sets out weak, and the journey takes longer and hurts more than it would have.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Later he admits he would be stronger in body and spirit, and would probably have found new cheese by now, if he had expected change instead of spending that time denying it had already happened.

IN PRACTICE

Price the delay explicitly. Not “should I move” but “what will this cost me per month of not deciding, in strength, options, and credibility.”

Remember — You do not get to make the journey later at today's strength.

IMPORTANT INSIGHTS · PART 3 OF 4

What Actually Breaks the Freeze

Four mechanisms, in the order Haw uses them. None of them requires new information.

Laughing at the loop drops an argument you cannot win

WHAT IT SAYS

Haw does not get unstuck by deciding to be brave, making a plan, or learning anything. He begins laughing at himself: look at us, we keep doing the same things over and over and wonder why things do not get better. Looking back later, he realizes he started to change as soon as he learned to laugh at himself and at what he had been doing wrong. The story's claim is that the fastest way to change is to laugh at your own folly — then you can let go and quickly move on.

WHY IT MATTERS

Hem's position is coherent within its own terms, which means you cannot refute it, including when it is yours. Laughter does not refute it. It drops it. It is the one move that removes the whole scaffolding at no cost to the ego, because the person laughing built the scaffolding.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Blanchard's real-world case follows the same sequence. Charlie Jones, reassigned from Track and Field to Swimming and Diving, was angry and said it was not fair — then heard the story, laughed at himself, and adapted. The reassignment never changed.

IN PRACTICE

Laugh at the pattern, not at yourself as a person. "I have now driven to this empty parking lot eleven times" is usable. Contempt for yourself is just another reason to stay.

Remember — You cannot out-argue your own reasons. You can decline to keep taking them seriously.

The fear question names the action; it does not remove the fear

WHAT IT SAYS

Anxious at the mouth of the maze, Haw writes a question on the wall and stares at it: what would you do if you were not afraid? It returns at his lowest point, when he is lost and weak and considering turning back. Immediately after writing it he draws a distinction: some fear is good, because when you are afraid things will get worse if you do nothing, it prompts action — but it is not good when it keeps you from doing anything at all.

WHY IT MATTERS

The question is routinely mistaken for a slogan about confidence. It asks for none. It asks you to name the specific action fear is currently vetoing. Once the action has a name, the fear stands beside it instead of in front of it — and you can be afraid and still put your shoes on.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Haw also swaps out an unanswerable question for an answerable one. Instead of “what if there is no cheese out there,” he asks: where am I more likely to find cheese, here or in the maze? The first question has no answer, which is exactly why it makes such a good hiding place.

IN PRACTICE

Apply the functional test rather than the emotional one: does this fear produce movement or paralysis? Fear that says “this is getting worse, get up” is working. Fear that says “stay, it is dangerous out there” is Hem’s line.

Remember — Name the action fear is vetoing. The fear can come along.

Specificity is the technique — a vivid destination outpulls a familiar comfort

WHAT IT SAYS

Haw paints a picture in his mind twice, and both times the detail is the method. Not “things will work out” but Swiss cheese with holes in it, bright orange cheddar, Italian mozzarella, soft French Camembert. The story’s claim: the more clearly he saw the image of himself finding and enjoying new cheese, the more he saw himself leaving Cheese Station C.

WHY IT MATTERS

The pull backward is concrete — a known room, a known routine, actual slippers. A vague better future cannot compete with that. The specificity is not decoration; it is what makes the destination weigh anything.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

The same mechanism scales. Michael’s job as a leader, he realizes, was to paint a picture of new cheese that everyone would want to pursue. And Richard’s admission about his children names the failure mode: maybe he has not painted a realistic picture of new cheese for them, probably because he does not see it himself.

IN PRACTICE

Write the destination in sensory, checkable detail — what a Tuesday looks like, what is on the calendar, what you are no longer doing. If you cannot picture it, you cannot ask anyone else to move toward it either.

Remember — Johnson offers no evidence for this beyond the story. The mechanism he describes is motivational, not magical: clarity about the destination outweighs the comfort of the room.

Belief changes before behavior, which is why willpower is the wrong lever

WHAT IT SAYS

Mid-journey Haw notices that he used to believe cheese should never be moved and that change was not right — and now believes change occurs continually whether you expect it or not. Old beliefs do not lead you to new cheese, he writes. Then he names the mechanism: when you change what you believe, you change what you do. You can believe a change will harm you and resist it, or believe finding new cheese will help you and embrace it.

WHY IT MATTERS

This answers the strongest objection to the whole book — that telling someone to just move is useless, because if they could, they would have. Hem is not short of a plan. He holds a belief, and the standing still is downstream of it. Change the belief and leaving stops requiring willpower.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Michael's Hems did not respond to urgency. They changed when they saw a sensible vision showing how changing would work to their advantage, and when they recognized the real danger of not changing. Their stated need was security, so the case had to be made in that currency.

IN PRACTICE

Find the sentence underneath the stuckness — “this should not be happening,” “I am owed,” “out there is dangerous” — and work on that sentence rather than on your own discipline.

Remember — Behavior is downstream. Argue with the belief, not with yourself.

IMPORTANT INSIGHTS · PART 4 OF 4

Staying Out, and Bringing Others

The last three are the ones almost everyone forgets, and the reason the book loops.

The arrival is where it went wrong last time

WHAT IT SAYS

The story does not end when Haw finds Cheese Station N. He hangs his shoes around his neck the way the mice do, in case he needs them again. Then he inspects the station every day to see what condition his cheese is in, and regularly goes out into the maze to explore even though he has plenty — because he knows it is safer to be aware of his real choices than to isolate himself in his comfort zone.

WHY IT MATTERS

Cheese Station N is structurally identical to Cheese Station C. The only difference is what Haw does after arriving. Every element of the original trap — the slippers, the relocated homes, the sayings on the wall — was a response to success, not to failure.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

The final reminder loops back to the first: be ready to change quickly and enjoy it again and again, because they keep moving the cheese. The book ends on a question rather than a period — the end, or is it a new beginning?

IN PRACTICE

Build the inspection into the good times, because that is the only time you will have the slack to do it and the only time it feels unnecessary.

Remember — There is no final cheese station. Keep the shoes around your neck.

You cannot carry anyone out — you can leave a trail

WHAT IT SAYS

Haw walks back to Cheese Station C with new cheese in his pocket and offers it to Hem. Hem declines: it is not what I am used to, I want my own cheese back, and I am not going to change until I get what I want. Later Haw considers going back again and stops himself, realizing Hem has to find his own way, beyond his comforts and past his fears — no one can do it for him or talk him into it.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the hardest instruction in the book for anyone who has already moved. Haw brought physical evidence from the actual maze and it did not work, because the condition was never a shortage of information.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Frank's friend, whose department was closing, was told repeatedly about other opportunities for people willing to be flexible. He was the only person surprised when the department closed.

IN PRACTICE

Stop making the case. Instead leave a visible, followable record of the route you took — what you did, in what order, what it cost — where they will find it if they ever decide to move.

Remember — Persuasion is not available. A trail is.

A change imposed is a change opposed — so move the peer pressure

WHAT IT SAYS

Michael observes that the further down an organization you go, the more people feel they have less power, and the more afraid they are of what a change imposed from above will do to them — so they resist. His summary: a change imposed is a change opposed. And when asked why his people finally changed, he does not credit insight. They changed, he says, after the peer pressure in the company changed.

WHY IT MATTERS

He is precise about the original mechanism: when a change is announced, people say it is a bad idea, and they may not even feel that way — they agree in order to fit in. That is the peer pressure that fights change in any organization. The story did not make the change more attractive; it made standing still more embarrassing.

STRONGEST EXAMPLE

Michael's one-line explanation of what shifted: no one wanted to look like Hem. People wanted to sniff out the changes ahead of time and scurry into action rather than get hemmed in and be left behind.

IN PRACTICE

Give the whole group a shared, funny, non-accusatory vocabulary before you need it — and be honest that it works because it changes what is socially safe, not because it changes anyone's mind.

Remember — Michael also had to let go the Hems who never changed. This is a real cost, and it is why the story is resented when it arrives with a layoff.

DEFINITIONS AND DISTINCTIONS

Terms Worth Keeping Straight

Most misreadings of this book come from collapsing one of these pairs.

cheese vs. Cheese

The mice hunt the hard nibbling cheese they like. The Littlepeople hunt Cheese with a capital C, which they believe will make them feel happy and successful. For the mice it is food; for the Littlepeople it is meaning — and meaning is what you cannot put down.

Old Cheese vs. Old Behavior

Angela's correction in the discussion, and the sharpest amendment in the book. What needs letting go is often the behavior causing the bad situation rather than the situation itself. Cory: the new cheese is a new relationship with the same person. If the old cheese is a behavior, leaving takes it with you.

Useful fear vs. paralyzing fear

Fear that warns things will get worse if you do nothing prompts action and should be respected — it can keep you out of real danger. Fear that keeps you from doing anything is the other kind. The test is functional: movement or paralysis.

Activity vs. productivity

What Haw realizes after the hole in the wall. Starting earlier, staying longer, and working harder in a place where the thing you need no longer exists produces effort and no result.

Managing vs. leading

Laura's five-word diagnosis of Michael: he was managing daily problems twenty-four hours a day when he should have been looking ahead and paying attention to where they were going — and painting a picture of new cheese people would want to pursue.

Reacting to change vs. moving your own cheese

Nathan's conclusion, and a step past the parable itself: it is a lot better to initiate change while you can than to react and adjust to it. He wonders where they would be if they had sold the real estate under the old stores and built one great modern store.

Someone moved it vs. it ran out

Jessica's amendment: it is not just that they moved the cheese — the cheese has a life of its own and eventually runs out. Not every loss has an author, and the title question is itself part of the trap, because looking for the agent is how you spend a year not moving.

ESSENTIAL STORIES AND EXAMPLES

The Six Worth Retelling

Five come from the book; the first is the one real-world case Blanchard supplies.

Charlie Jones and the swimming assignment

Blanchard's one real example. A well-regarded American sports broadcaster is pulled off Track and Field for the next Olympics and reassigned to Swimming and Diving. He does not know the sports, feels unappreciated, says it is not fair, and his anger starts affecting everything he does. Then he hears the cheese story, laughs at himself, adapts, learns the two new sports — and finds that doing something new makes him feel young. Better assignments follow.

The point: Nothing external changed. Nobody gave him the old assignment back. What changed is that he stopped litigating it — and the laughing came first, the adapting second.

The hole in the wall

Convinced the cheese must be hidden behind the wall, Hem holds the chisel while Haw swings the hammer. They find nothing, then start earlier, stay longer, and work harder. After a while all they have is a large hole in a wall.

The point: The cleanest picture in the book of denial that looks exactly like diligence — and the moment Haw first sees the difference between activity and productivity.

Cheese in the pocket

Haw walks all the way back to Cheese Station C carrying bits of new cheese to share, and offers them to his friend. Hem turns him down: it is not what I am used to, and I am not going to change until I get what I want.

The point: Proof does not move a Hem. This is the scene to remember before you make the case to someone for the fourth time.

The encyclopedia and the single disk

Jessica's company sold an encyclopedia as a set of more than twenty books. Someone proposed putting the whole thing on one computer disk — cheaper to make, easier to update, affordable to far more people. They all resisted, because the backbone of the business was a large door-to-door sales force whose commissions depended on the high price of the product. A competitor did it instead, and sales fell badly.

The point: The most precise anatomy of a Hem decision in the book, and none of it is stupidity. The cheese they were protecting was not the encyclopedia — it was the sales force.

The show of hands

Laura asks the group how many of them are afraid of change. One hand goes up. She asks how many think other people are afraid of change. Practically every hand goes up. Nathan supplies the one-word diagnosis: denial.

The point: A measurement rather than a joke. Your own sense that you are not the Hem in this situation is the least reliable evidence available to you.

Illinois to Vermont

Becky's family moved for her husband's job. Their son, a star swimmer, was furious — the new high school had no swim team. He fell in love with the mountains, took up skiing, skied on his college team, and now lives happily in Colorado. Her regret: if they had gone through the story together over hot chocolate, they could have saved the family a lot of stress.

The point: The book's domestic case, and the one that shows the vocabulary matters most before the change rather than after.

ACTIONABLE IDEAS

Nine Things to Actually Do

In order. The first two are set up before anything goes wrong, which is where this book's real leverage sits.

01

Name your cheese

WHAT TO DO

Write down, in specific terms, what you are currently depending on for your sense of safety, status, or happiness. Not “my career” — the particular arrangement you would grieve if it ended. Do this for work and for home separately.

WHEN TO USE IT

Once, before you use anything else here. Then revisit annually, or whenever something large shifts.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Everything else in the book operates on a named object. Unnamed dependencies cannot be inspected, priced, or replaced.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

You can say out loud what the loss would actually be, and it is more specific than a job title.

CAUTION

Expect this list to include things you would rather not admit you are relying on. That is the useful part of it.

02

Put a cheese inspection on the calendar

WHAT TO DO

For each item on that list, pick one or two observable signals that would tell you it is getting old — a client's reply time, a shrinking pipeline, a conversation you have stopped having at home — and set a recurring time to look at them. Monthly for the top two; quarterly for the rest.

WHEN TO USE IT

Now, while everything still looks fine. This is the one action that has to be set up before it is needed.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

The cheese ran out gradually. There were months of visible signal that nobody was looking at, because looking felt unnecessary while there was still cheese on the floor.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

You notice something small and unwelcome and you notice it early, in a scheduled half hour rather than in a crisis.

CAUTION

Inspection is not worry. Do it on a schedule and then stop; continuous monitoring collapses into anxiety and gets abandoned.

03

Laugh at the loop

WHAT TO DO

Describe out loud, in plain and slightly absurd terms, the exact repeating behavior you have been performing. "I have now rewritten the same proposal for a client who stopped answering in March." Say it to someone if you can.

WHEN TO USE IT

When you notice you are stuck and your reasons for staying still sound good.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

A coherent argument cannot be defeated from inside, including your own. Laughter drops it rather than refuting it — which the story calls the fastest way to change.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

You feel the grip loosen slightly, and the next practical question — where did I put my running shoes — becomes askable.

CAUTION

Laugh at the behavior, not at yourself. Self-contempt is not this tool; it is one more reason to stay put.

04

Ask the fear question, then write the answer down

WHAT TO DO

Ask: what would I do if I were not afraid? Write the answer as a single concrete action with a verb in it. Then ask the second question How uses: am I more likely to find what I need here, or out there?

WHEN TO USE IT

At any point where the reasoning has been going in circles for more than a week.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Fear operates best when the vetoed action stays nameless. Named, it becomes an item you can be afraid of and still do.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

You have one sentence on paper describing something you could do this week.

CAUTION

Then apply the functional test to the fear itself. Fear saying “this is getting worse, move” is doing its job and should be kept.

05

Paint the new cheese in checkable detail

WHAT TO DO

Describe the destination as a specific week rather than an outcome. What is on the calendar. Who you talk to. What you are no longer doing at eight in the morning. Keep going until it is boring and concrete.

WHEN TO USE IT

Immediately after the fear question, and again any time momentum drops.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

The pull backward is made of real, concrete things. A vague better future cannot outweigh actual slippers.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

You could hand the description to someone else and they could picture your Tuesday.

CAUTION

Johnson’s claim that imagining leads you to it is a claim from a story, offered without evidence. Treat the detail as motivational leverage, not as a mechanism that acts on the world.

06

Separate old cheese from old behavior

WHAT TO DO

Before you leave anything — a job, a relationship, a city — write down what you would be taking with you. Ask whether the thing you want to exit is the situation or a pattern you are performing inside it.

WHEN TO USE IT

Whenever the obvious answer is to leave.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

The parable's metaphor makes exit look like the answer. The group's own conclusion is that old cheese is frequently a behavior — and behaviors travel.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

You can state which it is, and if it is a behavior you have named the specific change in how you act rather than where you are.

CAUTION

This is not an argument for staying in genuinely finished situations. It is a check against relocating the same problem at cost.

07

Keep the shoes around your neck

WHAT TO DO

After any successful move, deliberately do not do the three things Hem and Haw did: do not build your whole social and physical life around the new arrangement, do not stop inspecting, and do not let your capacity to move decay. Concretely: keep one relationship warm outside your current situation, keep the skill you would need next current, and keep the inspection running.

WHEN TO USE IT

Starting the week things go well — which is the only week you will have slack for it and the only week it will feel unnecessary.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Cheese Station N is structurally identical to Cheese Station C. Everything that trapped them the first time was a response to success.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

A year into the good version, you could still leave inside a month.

CAUTION

This is not the same as holding back or refusing to commit. Haw enjoys the new cheese fully. He just does not put the shoes away.

08

Run the cheese conversation with your team or family

WHAT TO DO

Share the story, then ask three questions: who were you in a specific past change, what is our old cheese right now, and what could our new cheese be. Jessica's version at home and Michael's version at work are the same three questions.

WHEN TO USE IT

Before a change you can see coming — not during the one that has already landed.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

A change imposed is a change opposed, and the deeper into an organization you go the truer that gets. Shared vocabulary developed in advance is what lets a group discuss a change without defending against it.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

People start using the language on themselves unprompted — they moved our cheese, let us look for the new cheese — rather than having it used on them.

CAUTION

If you introduce this during a layoff or immediately after imposing a decision, it will read as exactly what it is, and it will poison the vocabulary permanently. Michael's own regret was not hearing it sooner.

09

Write The Facts of the Matter

WHAT TO DO

On one piece of paper, write only what you actually know: what has to happen, what the real risks are, and who is responsible for it. Hem's three lines were that he had to find cheese or die, that the maze was dangerous so he had to be careful, and that it was up to him — he was on his own. Put it in your pocket.

WHEN TO USE IT

When you are stuck alone, cannot get anywhere near laughing at it, and no one is coming.

THE PROBLEM IT ADDRESSES

Some situations are past the point where a vivid picture of the destination is available. This is the colder, shorter route — separate what you know from what you have been telling yourself, and go.

WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE

You know where things stand, which the excerpt notes felt reassuring to Hem. Then you move.

CAUTION

The third fact is the one that does the work and the one you will want to leave off. It is up to me is the sentence Hem spent the entire book refusing.

QUICK REFERENCE

One Page to Come Back To

THE SEQUENCE

Change Happens	They keep moving the cheese.
Anticipate Change	Get ready for the cheese to move.
Monitor Change	Smell the cheese often, so you know when it is getting old.
Adapt To Change Quickly	The quicker you let go of old cheese, the sooner you can enjoy new cheese.
Change	Move with the cheese.
Enjoy Change	Savor the adventure and enjoy the taste of new cheese.
Be Ready To Change Quickly, Again And Again	They keep moving the cheese.

THE FOUR RESPONSES

Sniff	Smells change coming while things still look fine.
Scurry	Moves as soon as the situation changes, without a long analysis.
Hem	Denies and resists, fearing change will lead to something worse.
Haw	Hesitates, then adapts in time once he sees change can lead to something better.

THE QUESTIONS

- Which of the four am I being, right now, about this particular thing?
 - What would I do if I were not afraid?
 - Am I more likely to find what I need here, or out there?
 - What is this costing me per month of not deciding?
 - Is my old cheese a situation, or a behavior I would take with me?
 - What would I grieve most — and when did I last inspect it?
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Change happens. They keep moving the cheese. The work is to notice it early, drop the argument for standing still, name somewhere specific to go — and then, once you arrive, keep the shoes around your neck.